Northwind Labs Employee Handbook

Test Edition - Version 1.0

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This handbook is a fictional document created for testing a RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) chatbot. All policies are made up.

Welcome and Company Values

Welcome to Northwind Labs. We are a team of about 250 people building software for the logistics industry. This handbook explains how we work, what you can expect from us, and what we expect from you.

Our Values

1. Customer first: every decision starts with the customer's needs.
2. Own it: take responsibility for outcomes, not only tasks.
3. Learn fast: mistakes are fine when we learn from them quickly.
4. Be kind: treat colleagues with respect and honesty.

Probation Period

All new employees have a probation period of 90 days. During probation, either side may end employment with 7 days' written notice. A probation check-in meeting with your manager is held at day 30, day 60, and day 90.

Working Hours and Remote Work

Core hours are 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM local time, Monday to Friday. Outside core hours you may choose your own schedule as long as you complete 40 hours per week.

Remote Work Policy

Employees may work remotely up to 3 days per week. Fully remote arrangements require written approval from a department head. Employees working remotely must be reachable on Slack during core hours and must attend all scheduled video meetings with the camera on when possible.

Home Office Allowance

Each employee receives a one-time home office allowance of 15,000 INR (or the local equivalent) to buy a chair, desk, or monitor. Receipts must be submitted within 60 days of purchase.

Performance Reviews

Northwind Labs conducts performance reviews **twice a year**: a **mid-year review in June** and an **annual review in December**. The purpose of each review is to evaluate goals, performance, and career development.

How a Review Works

Step 1 - Self-assessment: The employee completes a self-assessment form two weeks before the review.
Step 2 - Manager assessment: The manager rates performance on a scale of 1 to 5 across four areas: Delivery, Collaboration, Ownership, and Growth.
Step 3 - 1-on-1 session: A 45-minute meeting is held to discuss feedback and set goals.
Step 4 - Goal setting: Three to five SMART goals are agreed for the next period.

Rating Scale

Rating	Meaning
5	Outstanding - consistently exceeds expectations
4	Exceeds expectations
3	Meets expectations
2	Needs improvement
1	Unsatisfactory

Employees rated 4 or above in the annual review are eligible for a salary increase of 5% to 12%. Employees rated 2 or below are placed on a 60-day Performance Improvement Plan (PIP).

Booking a 1-on-1 Review Session

Review sessions are booked through the HR Assistant. To book, you must provide three details: your **full name**, your **work email**, and your preferred **time slot**.

Booking Steps

1. Tell the assistant which type of session you need (Performance Review, Career Discussion, or Benefits Consultation).
2. Provide your full name and work email.
3. Choose one of the available slots offered.
4. Receive a confirmation with a Reference ID (for example, #REV-4081).

Rules

Sessions can be rescheduled up to 24 hours before the start time. A no-show without notice counts as a missed review, and the manager must reschedule within 5 working days. Each session lasts 45 minutes. Standard slots are available Monday to Friday between 10:00 AM and 5:00 PM IST.

Paid Time Off (PTO)

Full-time employees receive **24 days** of paid time off per calendar year, accrued at 2 days per month. Unused PTO can be carried over, up to a maximum of 10 days, into the next year.

Leave Types

Leave Type	Days per Year	Notes
Annual PTO	24	Needs manager approval 5 days in advance
Sick Leave	12	Medical certificate needed after 3 consecutive days
Parental Leave	180 (maternity) / 15 (paternity)	Can begin up to 4 weeks before due date
Bereavement	5	Immediate family
Public Holidays	10	See company calendar

To request PTO, submit the request in the HR portal at least 5 working days before your leave. Requests longer than 10 consecutive days require department head approval.

Health Insurance and Benefits

All full-time employees are covered by group health insurance from the first day of employment. Coverage includes the employee, spouse, and up to two children.

Benefits Summary

Benefit	Details
Health insurance	Sum insured of 5,00,000 INR per family, fully paid by company
Dental and vision	Up to 20,000 INR per year reimbursed
Wellness allowance	3,000 INR per month for gym or yoga membership
Learning budget	50,000 INR per year for courses and certifications
Retirement plan	Company matches 6% of basic salary into provident fund
Meal card	2,200 INR per month, tax-free

To add a dependent, contact HR within 30 days of the life event (marriage or birth). Benefits end on the last working day of employment.

Code of Conduct

All employees must act with integrity and respect. Harassment, discrimination, and bullying of any kind are strictly prohibited and may lead to immediate termination.

Conflict of Interest

Employees must disclose any outside business activity or financial interest that could conflict with Northwind Labs. Gifts from vendors worth more than 2,000 INR must be reported to HR.

Reporting Concerns

Concerns can be reported to your manager, to HR, or anonymously through the Ethics Hotline at ethics@northwind.example. Retaliation against anyone who reports a concern in good faith is prohibited. All reports are investigated within 15 working days.

Dress Code

Dress is business casual. Client-facing days may require formal attire.

Data Security and IT Policy

Company data must be protected at all times. Use only company-approved devices and software for work.

Password Rules

Passwords must be at least 12 characters long and changed every 90 days. Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for email, VPN, and the code repository.

Incident Reporting

Report lost devices or suspected phishing emails to security@northwind.example within 1 hour of discovery. Never share customer data over personal email or personal messaging apps.

AI Tool Usage

Employees may use approved AI assistants for drafting and coding help, but must never paste customer data, credentials, or source code marked 'Confidential' into any AI tool.

Expenses and Travel

Business expenses are reimbursed when they are reasonable, necessary, and supported by receipts. Submit claims in the finance portal within 30 days.

Travel Limits

Item	Limit
Domestic flights	Economy class only
Hotel (metro city)	Up to 8,000 INR per night
Hotel (other city)	Up to 5,000 INR per night
Daily meal allowance	1,500 INR per day while traveling
Local transport	Actual cost with receipt

Trips longer than 5 days or any international travel need approval from the department head at least 14 days in advance.

Contacts and FAQ

HR Helpdesk: hr@northwind.example (replies within 1 working day)
IT Support: it@northwind.example
Finance: finance@northwind.example
Ethics Hotline: ethics@northwind.example

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: When do I get my salary?
A: Salaries are paid on the last working day of each month.

Q: How long is the notice period after probation?
A: 60 days for all employees.

Q: Can I carry over PTO?
A: Yes, up to 10 days (see page 6).

Q: How do I book a review session?
A: Use the HR Assistant (see page 5).

Q: Is there a company holiday in December?
A: Yes, the office closes from December 25 to January 1.